Dichotomy in Grief

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/58624918.

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Teen And Up Audiences

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No Archive Warnings Apply

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Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Adora & Catra (She-Ra)

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by Lidlove123

Summary

In the wake of the princess prom, Catra feels not victory, but confused anger and betrayal.

With the rebellion in shambles, it's all Adora can do to pull the people around her together, at the expense of her own emotional well-being.

Notes

This fic was inspired by this animatic which I adore and have watched so many times: https://youtu.be/0P5T3GyBaww?si=SU_1s9_7_EMBN2JF
you definitely don't have to watch it to understand the fic or anything but please watch it it's genuinely so good, it gives all the feelings I was trying to evoke with the story itself.

For reference the first part of this fic is set directly following Princess Prom, and the second half is during The Beacon after Glimmer and Bow have been rescued!

...so we're going to pretend that there's some kind of break in s1e10 The Beacon and it lasts more than one day because while I was writing it I went back and checked and basically from Princess Prom to Promise there's literally no breaks for Adora and co. the entire time, it's kind of a lot when you think about it.

See the end of the work for more notes

Catra couldn't stop thinking about the fear in Adora's eyes, the genuine terror that she had seen on Adora's face when she let go. She had thought it would be satisfying, *funny,* even, to make Adora experience what she had put Catra through, even for just a moment. The panic of not knowing whether the person she had just let slip away was alive or rotting somewhere, only to find out that Adora *hadn't* been dead, or brain damaged, or kidnapped, but that Catra had been abandoned by the one person in the world she had ever trusted.

"You look out for me, and I look out for you. Nothing really bad can happen as long as we have each other."

"You promise?"

"I promise."

Catra felt the tears welling up in her eyes and wailed, an angry roar which broke into a sob. She punched the wall and collapsed to the ground next to the lockers and cried and cried.

This was supposed to be her success. Her *moment* . She had gotten one up on Adora, on all the princesses. She had the sparkly one and the archer boy and Adora had no one.

Catra had wanted to take away everything of Adora's, everything she had *left* Catra for, like Adora had done to her when she'd defected. It had all been so simple in her head. But now, instead of triumph and revenge, Shadow Weaver got the credit and Catra got to keep being as confused and upset and *angry* as she had been for the last month.

"Catra? Are you alright in there?" Scorpia's frantic voice, accompanied by the sound of exoskeleton knocking against wood, came from the door to the barracks which Catra had firmly shoved a bench in front of in anticipation of her own breakdown. "Catra? Oh no, are you sick? Are you hurt? I'm coming in."

Before Scorpia could tear down the door, Catra snarled, "I'm fine! Leave me *alone,* Scorpia!"

The knocking stopped. "Are you sure?" when she got no reply, she didn't push. "Alright… I'm here if you need me."

When the sound of Scorpia's footsteps had faded, Catra hit the wall again. Her knuckles tore open and she watched with disinterest as blood dripped down her fingers, soaking into her fur or beading up and rolling down her claws.

How could Adora just leave her, just *replace* her like that? She had always known she was second best (had told herself she didn't care), but she had never been second best to Adora. And now she wasn't even on the list. She was angry, boiling inside, and sticky blood continued to drip down her hands like the hot tears down her face.

Catra stood up and faced the wall fully. She punched it, at first slowly and rhythmically, alternating hands, and then faster and angrier and over and over and over again until she felt something *crack* . She stumbled back, sitting hard on the bench not pushed against the door. She stared through the blur of still-streaming tears at the torn, ruined flesh of her hands and laughed until she sobbed until she screamed.

There was knocking on the door again, faint through the ringing in her ears and the sound of her own heaving sobs. She ignored them. They eventually stopped.

Seconds or minutes or hours later, depleted and numb, Catra stumbled from the bench to the back corner of the room, where she could see every entrance and exit. She curled up and eventually fell asleep, utterly alone.

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Adora couldn't stop thinking about the look on Catra's face when she handed her the sword. The anger in her eyes as she dragged it, sparking, along the wall. The derision as she passed it into

Adora's hands. And then, almost worse, her disappearance before Adora could– could what? Capture her? Thank her? Punch her or kiss her or scream at her or get down on her knees and beg for her forgiveness?

She tried to reason with herself. It wouldn't have mattered anyway. It's not like she would have had time to do any of that. They were in the middle of the Horde compound in an emergency rescue situation. So it doesn't matter in the first place whether or not Catra stuck around for ten more seconds. (She tried to ignore the incessant voice in her head that says Catra left because she already knew Adora didn't deserve her forgiveness.)

A guilty part of Adora's brain reminded her she had more important things to think about. Glimmer was glitching, Entrapta was- was *dead,* the alliance had fallen apart. They had never been in a worse position.

But she had been thinking about that all day. Talking to Glimmer and Bow and Angella, putting on a brave face, her She-Ra face. Reassuring and planning and comforting and hiding.

Adora was tired and sad and *so* lonely. Staring up at the ceiling, in her too-soft bed, in this too-bright kingdom, she could only see the betrayal in Catra's eyes when they first fought in Thaymor, the anger in subsequent battles, the dismissal of their most recent meeting.

She hardly even noticed when the first tears welled in her eyes, until they were sliding down the sides of her face and dripping into her hair and onto her pillow. She cried silently for several minutes, eyes still fixed on the darkness above her, until quite suddenly it all became too much.

She gasped as if in physical pain, and her tears began to come in choked sobs. She turned onto her side and clutched desperately at her middle, curling her knees up until she was almost in the fetal position. Adora laid there and cried as quietly as she could manage. She dug her nails deeply into the flesh of her sides as

hot tears carved trails down her cheeks, dripping down her nose. Her throat felt hoarse and choked.

There was a soft knocking on her door, and it cracked open, letting a beam of light cut across her floor. She could barely make out Bow's face as he poked his head into the room.

"Adora? I just wanted to check in, I know it's been a long day…"

Adora stayed silent and unmoving. He wouldn't be able to tell her eyes were open in the darkness of the room. He seemed to pause for a moment before he sighed and left, carefully shutting the door behind him.

She stayed tense and silent for the next few minutes, and then relaxed her legs and unclenched her hands. She didn't understand why she wouldn't talk to Bow about this, but she just *couldn't* . She couldn't. That thought brought a fresh wave of tears, and she raised her hands up to grip the roots of her hair.

Adora laid there, tears dripping down her face, tugging her own hair, struggling to breathe, until she drifted off into fitful sleep, lonelier than she ever remembered being in the Horde.

End Notes

So I've never before written the hurt without the comfort it just makes me sad... but I just started college and I'm feeling so lonely as of late so it was honestly more projection than anything.
I really hope y'all liked it anyway though, I was honestly very happy with how it turned out.

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!